

(When) Do Replications Influence the Impact of Original Claims? A Bibliometric Investigation.

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Abstract

Replication is a cornerstone of cumulative science, providing essential insights into the robustness and generalisability of research findings. Yet, despite an increasing number of published replications, they often fail to affect the belief in, and use of, the original conclusions (Hardwicke et al., 2021). Replications are infrequently cited, often disregarded in theoretical discussions, and—except for striking exceptions—fail to shift research agendas. This raises a critical question: If replications are fundamental to scientific self-correction, why do their results so often fail to shape knowledge?

In this proposed study, we will use the FORRT Library of Replication Attempts (FLoRA), which includes 800 failed replications from across the social and behavioural sciences, to analyse the effect of failed replications on subsequent citations of their target studies. We will fit a Fixed Effects Counterfactual model (FECT) (Liu, Wang, & Xu, 2024), a method for causal

inference in longitudinal data which combines features of synthetic control and difference-in-difference, to the citation data for studies that have a failed replication in FLoRA, and a sample of control studies.

In a second step, we will analyse the treatment effects for individual studies from the FECT model using meta-analytic regression (Viechtbauer, 2025). This will test whether the citation impact of failed replications is moderated by pre-specified characteristics of the replication or the original study (e.g., open-access status, journal rank, author composition or research field).

In doing so, this study will (a) estimate the causal effect of failed replications on citation rates of original studies, and (b) identify characteristics that moderate this effect. Understanding what makes some replications more influential than others can inform strategies to increase their visibility and impact.

1 Motivation

Replications are a key mechanism of scientific self-correction. The process of re-testing original claims with new data is crucial for assessing the credibility of the original claims (Nosek & Errington, 2020). While published replication attempts have historically been rare (Koole & Lakens, 2012), recently there has been increased interest in replications. Large-scale efforts to systematically replicate findings in psychology (?), economics (?), experimental philosophy (?), or cancer biology (Errington et al., 2021) have revealed that many original studies do not replicate. However, replications can only contribute to scientific self-correction if their results are considered when evaluating original claims. This study aims to evaluate whether failed replication affects citations of original studies and what the moderators of this effect are, using the FORRT Library of Replication Attempts (FLoRA) (Röseler et al., 2024; Wallrich et al., 2026).

Previous literature on the topic is summarised in Tables 1 and 2. The reported estimates of the effect of replication on citation counts of original studies differ, with some suggesting a small decrease, while others suggest no effect (Ankel-Peters, Fiala, & Neubauer, 2025; Clark, Connor, &

Table 1

Studies looking at the effect of replication on citation outcomes in Psychology (or including Psychology if multiple fields).

Reference	Number of original studies	Field and outcome (MO)	Scope	Main results
Schafnkeister (2021)	$N=95$	Psychology, MO: yearly citation count	Failed and successful replications, studies replicated as part of the Open Science Collaboration, control group published in the same journals in adjacent months.	Successful replications led to increase in yearly citations of 5%, unsuccessful to decrease of 4%, both non-significant.
Serra-Garcia and Gneezy (2021)	$N=80$	Psychology, Economics and Nature/Science, MO: yearly citation counts	Studies included in 3 large-scale replication projects, studies from Camerer et al. (2016,2018), Open Science Collaboration (2015)	Papers that replicated received 153 fewer citations than papers that do not over their lifetime.
Hardwicke et al. (2021)	$N=5$	Psychology, MO: yearly citation counts and citation valence	Only failed replications, reference group of articles published same year and journal.	Modest decline in citations following replication or mixed trend, most citations positive in valence, most articles do not co-cite the replication study.
von Hippel (2022)	$N=98$	Psychology MO: yearly citation and co-citation count	Failed and successful replications, studies from Open Science Collaboration (2015).	Replication failure reduced citations by 9% - not significant, 3% of papers co-cite the replication.
Clark et al. (2023)	$N=228$	Psychology, MO: yearly citation counts.	Failed replications only collected through major replication projects and Google Scholar search.	Average citation decline of 14%.

Table 2

Studies looking at the effect of replication on citation outcomes in other fields.

Reference	Number of original studies	Field and main outcome (MO)	Scope	Main results
Coupe and Reed (2023)	$N=204$	Economics, MO: yearly citation counts.	Replications from The Replication Network and ReplicationWiki (Höfler, 2017), controls matched on pre-replication citation trend	Found no evidence that failed replications impact the citations of replicated studies.
Ankel-Peters et al. (2024)	$N=53$	Economics, MO: yearly citation counts	Replications published as comments in the American Economic Review between 2010 and 2020.	The publication of comments does not lead to a decrease in originals' citations, established via visual inspection of citation trends only.
Hensel and Kacprzak (2024)	$N=135$	Management, MO: co-citation counts.	Failed and successful replications published between 1960-2015.	Replications co-cited with originals 7.8% of the time, average citing journal IF, author-dependency, and journal dependency positive impact on co-citation count.

Isch, 2023; Coupé & Reed, 2023; Hardwicke et al., 2021; Hensel & Kacprzak, 2024; Schafmeister, 2021; Serra-Garcia & Gneezy, 2021; von Hippel, 2022). Studies looking at co-citation rates mostly find that replications are rarely cited alongside the original studies, but with large variability for individual studies. What distinguishes influential replications from those with little impact was previously rarely studied. Additionally, most previous studies used either data from large-scale projects or individual replication attempts, but none have systematically looked at whether there are differences in impact between those. Studies looking at more than one field in combination are also currently rare.

2 Research questions

The current study aims to evaluate whether the presence of failed replication affects citation rates of original studies and to identify factors that predict the strength of this effect, using studies from the FORRT Library of Replication Attempts (FLoRA) (Röseler et al., 2024). In particular, we are interested in the following research questions:

- Do failed replications decrease the citation counts of original studies (for two outcomes separately: yearly citations and yearly citations without co-citations)? Most previous studies have used one of those as the outcome. We believe that evaluating the effect on both of the outcomes gives an upper and lower bound of a range of the true effect of failed replications on the influence of original studies.
- Which factors moderate this effect?

We have selected moderators based on previous literature and based on the personal experience of the authors. The moderators broadly fall within categories of visibility of the replication (e.g., publication status), link between the replication and original (e.g., author and journal dependency), and context (subject field).

We predict there will be a negative effect of failed replications on the outcome variables (yearly citations and yearly citations without co-citations). In line with previous literature, we predict that a stronger link between replication and original (in particular, journal dependency (Hensel & Kacprzak, 2024)) will have a positive effect on the replication impact. We also predict that higher visibility of replication will have a positive effect on the replication impact.

3 Methods

Data

We will analyse original studies for which there are only failed replication attempts from within the FORRT Library of Replication and Reproduction Attempts (FLoRA) (FORRT, 2025; Hartmann et al., 2025; Röseler et al., 2024). The replication outcome will be based on the reported interpretation of the replication authors. We consider replications that were published between 2011 to 2021. The beginning of this time period was the start of "replication crisis" where an interest in replication outcomes became theoretically more prevalent, the end was set to allow potential effects to become visible. FLoRA is currently being extended, and we expect it to include $\tilde{800}$ -1000 failed replications by the time of analysis. FLoRA is an extension of the FORRT Replication Database (FReD). FLoRA covers more replications from a wider range of fields, but provides less information per study, with some of our proposed moderators available only for the subset that has originally been part of FReD. We will therefore run an exploratory moderator analysis that includes only the FReD data in addition to the main moderator analysis on the full sample.

Comparator Pool

For estimation, we need a large donor pool of non-replicated articles to estimate counterfactual trajectories. For each replicated (original) study, we identify related non-replicated articles. We

proceed in three steps. First, we identify a set of comparable journals for each original article based on three criteria: (a) publication in the same calendar year, (b) at least one shared SCImago disciplinary category, and (c) a similar SCImago Journal Rank (SJR, $\pm 25\%$, (SCImago, 2019)). If the SJR is unavailable for the journal in the publication year, we use the SJR from the nearest available year. If a journal never received an SJR, we restrict the donor pool to articles published in the original journal in the original publication year. Otherwise, we identify up to six closely matched journals (including the journal in which the article has been published), based on the most similar SJRs. If fewer than three are available under strict matching criteria, we relax the SJR criterion until at least three journals are obtained. Second, we retrieve the full set of articles published in each of the matched journals in the focal year using the OpenAlex API (Priem, Piwowar, & Orr, 2022). Third, from each donor pool, we randomly draw 10 articles to serve as comparison units, excluding articles that have already been drawn for another replicated original. These sampled control articles, together with their citation histories obtained from Scopus and OpenCitations (Peroni & Shotton, 2020), form the comparator units in the fec estimator.

It is of note that for articles cited 0 times, no citation counts will be returned. This may also however arise from articles not indexed in that API. For articles which had 0 returned citations, we recheck citation counts using Scopus API (in the Scopus pathway) and OpenAlex API (for the OpenCitations pathway). Only if 0 citations are confirmed using this approach for a given article, this article is used in the comparator pool with 0 citations for each year since its publication. Otherwise the comparator article is removed without resampling.

Sample size and sensitivity

We have run a sensitivity analysis to evaluate our ability to detect an effect of interest with the expectation of FLoRA containing 800 failed replications at the time of analysis. However, in practice we will use the full amount of failed replications that will be available when we start the analysis.

To generate realistic citation patterns, we first calculated summary statistics from 10,000 real

control studies: first-year citations, total years of observation, cumulative total citations, and mean citations in the first three years (early growth). We modeled the joint distribution of these summaries using a Gaussian copula, which preserves both the empirical marginal distributions and the dependence structure among variables. We then drew 100,000 synthetic studies from this multivariate distribution.

For the simulation, we constructed yearly citation trajectories consistent with the sample summary statistics. For treated studies ($N = 10,000$), we imposed a Poisson thinning in yearly citations of 10%, 15%, 20%, or 25%, beginning after the hypothetical failed replication.

We ran the *fect* difference-in-differences model (Liu et al., 2022, 2026). Simulations were run 100 times for each effect size, always sampling 800 treated and 8000 untreated studies. Power was calculated as the proportion of simulations in which the estimated effect was negative (as modeled) and statistically significant at $\alpha = 0.05$.

Results of the power simulation are outlined in the Table 3.

Table 3

Results from power simulation for the fect model.

Effect size (%)	N treated	N untreated	Power
25	800	8000	0.91
20	800	8000	0.82
15	800	8000	0.77
10	800	8000	0.59

Metadata and citation data extraction procedure

First, to acquire metadata for the studies within the FLoRA database, we will use the OpenAlex API to query the DOIs of individual studies. The ISSN and publication year field will

be used to match articles to journals and identify control journals from the Scimago Journal & Country Rank data (SCImago, 2019), acquired through the `sjrdata` package (Kashnitsky, 2025) in R (R Core Team, 2023). We will then extract citation data for each of the articles in the FLoRA database and the control group using two sources (a) the Scopus Citation API and (b) the Open Citations API (Peroni & Shotton, 2020). This will lead to two sets of citation data, which will be analysed separately using the procedure described below. A study published in 2021 (Martín-Martín, Thelwall, Orduna-Malea, & Delgado López-Cózar, 2021) showed that Open Citations detected only about 44% of citations detected by Scopus on the same sample. While there are no more recent estimates, and this number has probably increased over the years, Scopus is still likely to be more comprehensive. Therefore, we use Scopus as our primary analysis. However, for broad future reproducibility, we will also report the results from a fully open citation database.

3.1 Moderators

To evaluate what makes some replications more impactful than others, we will test the effect of the following moderators.

Years since the replication has been published: It may take time for scientists to become aware of the publication of a replication study. We will therefore assess the years since the replication has been published.

Subject field of original study: Replications are closely linked with the Open Science reform, which has been adopted across disciplines at varying paces. Consequently, replication impact may vary by field. To account for this, we control for subject fields using the classification system of the German Federal Statistical Office (German Federal Statistical Office, 2021). Given the absence of a consistent data source for article classifications, we employ an open-weights LLM (*gpt-oss-120B*) to code subject fields based on article titles, abstracts, and journal names (see

GUIDE-LLM checklist (Feuerriegel, Stefan, 2025) in Supplementary Material for full details). The model classifies articles into one or two primary subject areas and research fields. Classification relies primarily on journal titles to minimize interpretation, except in cases of multidisciplinary journals. To balance granularity with parsimony, we initially assign broad "Subject Areas" (e.g., Psychology, Economics); if an area contains over 100 studies, it is further divided into specific "Subject Fields." We validated this procedure by comparing LLM outputs against human coding ($N=250$) and an independent frontier model, Gemini 3.1 Pro. There was an overall agreement between the two models for 94.4% of the articles, justifying our further use of the open-weights LLM for the full study. There was an agreement of 92% between manual coding and the LLM model with Cohen's kappa of 0.777. For the final analysis, fields or areas with fewer than 10 observations will be collapsed into an 'Other' category at each level (i.e. field with less than 10 observations will be collapsed to other category for this area, area with less than 10 observations will be collapsed into general other category on the level of areas).

Availability of replication: Whether replication is open access or published behind a pay-wall may influence the ability of researchers to read it, and this may decrease its effect on citation counts. We will gather data on open access using the Unpaywall API (<https://unpaywall.org/products/api>) and use this as a binary indicator.

Replication and original study published in the same or different journal: We will include a binary variable to check for the moderating effect of publishing replications in the same journal as the original.

Author overlap between replication and original : Binary variable indicating whether the author team of the replication includes at least one author of the original (assessed using OpenAlex author IDs that aim to disambiguate authors with common names).

Seniority of authors of the replication: Replication studies co-authored by senior figures

within the field could have a larger impact if the authors are viewed as more trustworthy, or simply better placed to disseminate their results. Different proxies for academic seniority have been used in previous literature. We will operationalise the seniority of authors as the maximum h -index of the first and last author of the study at the time the study was published.

We will get the h -index for the relevant years by using Scopus (or OpenAlex, for the open pathway) to identify all papers published by that author up to the year of publication, and then use Scopus (or OpenAlex) to retrieve the number of citations for each paper up to that year. An author's h -index is then defined such that a given researcher has h publications which each has at least h citations.

Publication strategy: This will be a 3 level moderator with level published, unpublished (e.g., a preprint), and published as part of a large meta-paper. Being part of a large meta-paper focused on the replicability of a field might both increase the visibility or conceal the results of a specific replication. We will operationalise studies that replicate more than 3 originals as being a meta-paper and those replicating fewer than or equal to 3 originals as likely focusing on a specific phenomenon.

Source Normalized Impact per Paper (SNIP) of the replication study's journal: Previous studies identify journal prestige as a potential moderator of the effects of failed replications (Hensel & Kacprzak, 2024), as studies published in higher-impact outlets may be more visible and perceived as credible. However, traditional impact factors do not account for field-specific citation practices and can act as proxies for disciplinary differences. To address this, we used the SNIP metric (Waltman, van Eck, van Leeuwen, & Visser, 2013), which normalizes impact based on each journal's subject field. We extract this data from (Studies (CWTS), n.d.) and use the value corresponding to the year the replication was published. Given that SNIP is not available for replications that have not been published in a journal, we will first center the SNIP factor values,

assign 0 to all unpublished works, and use a missingness indicator in the model. This approach will allow us to use all data in the model, while keeping the interpretation of the SNIP factor result restricted to articles that are in journals with assigned SNIP.

3.2 Additional moderators only available in FReD

Some theoretically relevant variables are coded only in FReD, the (smaller) FORRT Replication Database that includes a wide range of statistical information. These will only be included in an exploratory metaCART analysis run on the subset of the data for which these moderators are available.

Preregistration of replication - Preregistration may increase the trust researchers have in the outcomes of a replication study. We will therefore include a binary variable on whether the replication study included a preregistration.

Square root of sample size ratio - Calculated as the square root of original study N divided replication study N . It will be interpreted as an indicator of precision. Maximum sample sizes used within the analyses will be used for this calculation.

Analysis plan

The analysis plan below will be run using two outcomes: the first will be citation counts of original studies, second citation without co-citation. These outcomes reflect optimistic and conservative estimate of the effect of failed replications so that the true effect of failed replication is likely to be within the range of the two effects gained by this approach. The analysis plan is summarised below and also in Table 4.

Table 4

Study design table

Research question	Type of result	Outcome	Method	Replication data
Do failed replications decrease the citation counts of original studies	Main	Citation counts	fect model	FLoRA
Which factors moderate the effect?	Main	Citation without co-citation	fect model	FLoRA
		Citation counts	metafor	FLoRA
	Explorative	Citation without co-citation	metafor	FLoRA
		Citation counts	metaCART	FLoRA
		Citation without co-citation	metaCART	FLoRA
	Explorative	Citation counts	metaCART	FReD (extended set of moderators)
				FReD (extended set of moderators)

Note. These will also be run using OpenCitations API as the data source as a secondary analysis.

The analysis procedure was developed on a subset of 101 studies in the FLoRA database that have a failed replication. This data was an early subset from the overall data being double-coded and extended for a partner project between FORRT and COS (Training (FORRT), 2024).

Effect of failed replication on study influence

Our first objective is to estimate the causal effect of failed replications on the citation counts of original studies. To do so, we employ the Fixed Effects Counterfactual (FECT) model (Liu et al., 2024). This method improves upon standard synthetic control and difference-in-difference approaches by estimating a latent factor structure from untreated units to generate counterfactual predictions. This controls for unobserved time-varying covariates such as the shifting popularity of specific subfields that might differentially affect citation trajectories. The model estimates the Average Treatment Effect on the Treated (ATT) by imputing the counterfactual outcome (the expected citation count had there been no failed replication) based on the factor structure learned from the untreated units. The ATT is calculated as the difference between the actual citation count and this estimated counterfactual.

We will run the model with two outcome variables separately. One is raw citation counts

per year. Second is the raw citation without co-citation counts per year. For both, the start of treatment is specified by the year in which the replication study was published. We include fixed effects for original journals and publication years, alongside time-varying covariates for the annual SCImago journal rank of the original journal to adjust for evolving venue prestige and article age squared (Age^2) due to non-linear citation life-cycles. The counterfactual imputation will be done via the interactive fixed effects algorithm (IFE). We will decide the number of factors (r) for the model based on the minimal mean squared prediction as recommended by (Liu et al., 2024). Based on this r , we will select the minimum number of pre-treatment years as $r + 1$. Note that to do that, we first have to run the model to select the number of factors, then modify the minimum number of pre-treatment years, and run the model again. Only the second model’s result will be used and reported. Standard errors are estimated via cluster bootstrapping at unit level, with a statistical significance threshold of $\alpha = .05$. To assess whether the model assumptions are met, we will report placebo and equivalence tests.

As a robustness check we will analyse the same outcomes using the Extended Two-Way Fixed Effects Model (ETWFE) (?) with a Poisson estimator. ETWFE is a type of two-way fixed effects model which fully saturates the regression model with cohort $\times$ time interaction terms, to avoid the use of already treated units as controls when treatment is staggered. Compared to FECT, ETWFE is relatively immune to short pre-treatment periods. However, ETWFE relies on a parallel trends assumption that treated and control articles would have followed the same citation trajectory absent replication failure. This may be violated if articles selected for replication are systematically high-impact papers with distinct citation trajectories compared to other articles published in the same journal and year. FECT’s IFE estimation instead relies on a low-rank structure assumption which assumes citation trajectories are driven by a small number of common factors, with unit-specific loadings. This may be more precise assumption in this case.

In the robustness check, we include the same time-varying covariates as in the main model

(annual SCImago journal rank, and square article age).

3.2.1 Moderators of the effect of failed replication

To examine predictors of treatment effects, we employ a two-stage approach. In the first stage, we extract the unit-specific, time-specific ATT estimates and their associated bootstrapping standard errors from the FECT model. In the second stage, we fit a multilevel meta-analytic mixed-effects model using the `rma.mv` function in the R package *metafor* (Viechtbauer, 2025), with estimates weighted by their inverse variance and including a random intercept for each original study.

We will use the unit-specific, time-specific ATTs for years 2 to 6 (or 2 to 5 for replications published in 2021) to allow for time before the replication can reasonably influence citation practices and to use a time window comparable across studies. We then model “time since replication” and “time since replication”² as continuous moderators to assess whether treatment effects grow, diminish, or stabilise over time.

With regard to additional moderators, we limit the set to those with the greatest theoretical interest to keep the model parsimonious. Specifically, we focus on three clusters of predictors:

- the **visibility** of the replication, indicated by the time-specific Source Normalised Impact Factor of the journal it was published in, the seniority of the replication authors, and whether it remained unpublished/preprinted, was published on its own or as part of a large-scale ‘Many Labs’ style project.
- the **link between original and replication**, indicated by whether original and replication were published in the same journal, whether there was overlap in the author teams of original and replication study, and by the time elapsed *between* the publication of original and

replication study,

- the **context**, indicated by the subject area of the original study.

As a robustness check, we will compute a single pooled ATT for each study (the inverse-variance weighted mean across all years ≥ 2) and repeat the meta-analytic moderator analysis on these summary effects. We will also run the original analysis but drop seniority, as it may be causally related to the SNIP factor (in that more senior authors publish in more visible journals), and including both might inflate variance and reduce power.

Exploratory analysis of moderators

Potential moderators of the treatment effect may interact in complex, non-linear ways. To explore this high-dimensional space, we employ metaCART (Li, Dusseldorp, & Meulman, 2017), an adaptation of Classification and Regression Trees (Breiman, Friedman, Olshen, & Stone, 1984) for effect-size data. We specify the unit-specific, time-specific ATTs from the FECT model as the dependent variable, alongside the unit-specific, time-specific variance required for weighting.

We will also run second metaCART model where we also include the moderators that are only available in the more detailed FReD data. We will run this model only on the subset of data which includes information these moderators.

MetaCART does not allow for inclusion of random intercepts. To address the non-independence of multiple yearly ATTs per study, we will use a study-level resampling approach. Over 5,000 iterations, we randomly select exactly one time-point observation from years 2 to 6 per study to construct a temporary dataset that meets the independence assumption of metaCART. We then aggregate results across all iterations, reporting the selection frequency of each moderator, the frequency with which a moderator appeared as the primary (root) split, and the distribution of split points within key moderators.

Data and code availability

Data and code for this preregistration is available at: https://github.com/JosefinaW/MARCO_BibliometricStudy

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